(and recalled to Peter Hutchausen and Svetlana Savranskaya), but was concerned that the political officer (or *zampolit)* would report any reluctance to do so.[40]

Under what circumstances was the Sixty-ninth Brigade authorised to fire its nuclear torpedoes? There is ambiguity about this, not least because there was ambiguity in the orders given to the captains. When the brigade was ready to depart from the Kola peninsula, the chief of staff of the northern fleet, Vice-Admiral Anatoli I. Rossokha, told the captains when they could fire the nuclear torpedo: first, if US depth charges ruptured the hull of the boat; second, if on surfacing, it was attacked and hit; third, on orders of the minister of defence.[41] Vice-Admiral Rossokha told the four captains that they should write this down in their log books. He added, 'I suggest to you commanders that you use the nuclear weapons first and then you will figure out what to do after that.' So, in at least two of the three circumstances, the Soviet navy would initiate the use of nuclear weapons. The first deputy head of the Soviet Navy, Admiral Vitalii Fokin, told the departing captains: 'If they slap you on the left cheek, do not let them slap you on the right one.'[42]

However, as Svetlana Savranskaya explains, when the captains opened their sealed orders, the written instructions were different: the torpedoes could only be fired on the specific orders of the minister of defence.[43] This is presumably what Khrushchev and the Presidium expected. It again invites speculation about how much Soviet leaders grasped operational realities and the potential consequences of their decisions.

It also emerged that the four captains made a 'pact' among themselves that if one fired his nuclear torpedo, the others would follow suit.[44] This could have resulted in immediate nuclear escalation (regardless of how US forces responded). Presumably, there was also the possibility that, if Vadim Orlov was correct about a risk of an accidental nuclear explosion on the B-59, one or more of the other captains might misunderstand the situation and fire their torpedo by mistake.

The toilet rolls that nearly blew up the world